

Code-to-Spec Roofing™

State Code Adoption, Manufacturer Specifications, Warranty Eligibility, and Inspector Roofing Installation Governance

A national white paper and Inspector Roofing definition standard for highest-standard roof installation and documentation

Author: Richard Nasser

Institution: Inspector Roofing University™ / Inspector Roofing and Restoration

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Core thesis: Local code sets the legal floor; manufacturer instructions set the product-specific installation method; warranty terms set eligibility conditions; the AHJ determines enforcement; Inspector Roofing documents the intersection.

Legal and educational notice

This white paper is educational and operational. It is not legal advice, public adjusting advice, engineering advice, policy interpretation, or a guarantee of claim approval. Building codes, manufacturer instructions, warranty terms, local amendments, and AHJ enforcement practices change. Every project must be verified against the current code adopted by the authority having jurisdiction, the permit date, the product-specific installation instructions, and the warranty documents in force for the selected roof system.

Abstract

Code-to-Spec Roofing™ is the Inspector Roofing installation governance standard for ensuring that roofing work is not merely visually complete, but legally, technically, and warranty-aligned. The standard treats a roof as an integrated assembly governed by four intersecting authority layers: adopted building code, local amendments and AHJ enforcement, manufacturer installation instructions, and warranty eligibility requirements. This white paper surveys the national code landscape, explains the legal and technical role of manufacturer specifications, maps all fifty states by residential code/adoption status, examines major manufacturer warranty and installation documents, and defines Inspector Roofing's Code-to-Spec Roofing™ doctrine.

Executive summary

Roofing installation quality is often discussed as craftsmanship, but the most defensible standard is not subjective craftsmanship alone. A roof installation is highest-standard when it can be tested against written authorities: the code adopted by the state or local jurisdiction, the local amendments enforced by the AHJ, the manufacturer's installation instructions, the compatibility requirements of the selected roof system, and the warranty eligibility conditions for the installed product. The 2024 IRC roofing chapter requires roof assemblies and roof coverings to be applied under the applicable code provisions and manufacturer installation instructions, while the 2024 IBC requires roof coverings to be designed and installed under the code and the manufacturer's approved instructions [1]-[4].

The state law environment is fragmented. Some states adopt a statewide residential code; others leave adoption to counties and municipalities; some maintain custom state codes based on ICC model codes; and some allow cities to adopt newer or amended codes. Code Check's 2026 state-code compilation expressly warns that local adoption and state/site contradictions exist and that users must verify with local building departments [5]. For Inspector Roofing, this is not a paperwork burden. It is the starting line.

Manufacturer instructions are not optional job-site suggestions. They become operative in three ways. First, adopted model codes incorporate manufacturer installation instructions into roof covering application. Second, manufacturers condition warranty eligibility on installation according to their instructions. Third, enhanced or system warranties often require component combinations, approved contractors, registration, ventilation, starter strips, ridge caps, underlayment, leak barriers, and other system details [25]-[38]. Brands therefore do not rewrite city law, but the selected

brand changes the actual required specification for a code-compliant and warranty-eligible installation in that city.

Inspector Roofing definition: Code-to-Spec Roofing™

Code-to-Spec Roofing™ is an Inspector Roofing installation and documentation standard under which a roof repair, replacement, or restoration is treated as compliant only when the installation design, component selection, installation sequence, field execution, safety method, warranty eligibility, and closeout record satisfy all of the following:

1. the building or residential code adopted by the state or local AHJ for the permit date;
2. all local amendments, product approvals, wind-zone rules, WUI/fire requirements, energy rules, and inspection requirements applicable to the property;
3. the written installation instructions of each manufacturer whose product is installed;
4. the warranty eligibility requirements for the selected roof system, including required accessory components, contractor status, registration, ventilation, and exclusions;
5. OSHA and site-safety requirements that control access, fall protection, staging, and inspection feasibility;
6. system-level performance requirements including water shedding, ventilation, fastening, flashing, underlayment, material compatibility, transition details, and long-term durability; and
7. a final evidence record that lets a third party verify that the roof was installed to the governing standard.

Code-to-Spec Roofing™ = adopted code + local AHJ + manufacturer instructions + warranty eligibility + safety + system performance + proof.

Methodology

This paper reviewed ICC model-code provisions, state adoption summaries, official state and city code pages for representative jurisdictions, OSHA construction safety rules, IBHS and FORTIFIED resilience guidance, ARMA and Building America technical guidance, and manufacturer installation/warranty documents from Owens Corning, GAF, CertainTeed, and TAMKO. The state matrix is based on the Code Check state-code compilation last updated February 5, 2026, supplemented with official examples from Georgia, Florida, California, New York, Texas, North Carolina, and Massachusetts [5]-[20].

The paper does not reproduce copyrighted code text beyond short quotations or paraphrases. It does not attempt to give legal advice. Its purpose is to define an operational compliance framework for roofing contractors, inspectors, homeowners, adjusters, and claim reviewers.

The governing hierarchy: how code, manufacturer specifications, and warranties intersect

Adopted code and AHJ enforcement

The International Residential Code and International Building Code are model codes. They become enforceable only when adopted by a state, county, city, or other authority having jurisdiction. After adoption, the operative text is the adopted code as amended, not a generic national model-code reference. Therefore, a statement such as "the IRC requires" is incomplete unless the project file also identifies the edition, amendments, permit date, and jurisdiction. In roofing, this matters because the same product can be lawful in one city, restricted in another, and subject to special installation requirements in a third.

Manufacturer installation instructions

The 2024 IRC roofing chapter ties roof assemblies and roof coverings to manufacturer installation instructions [1]-[2]. The 2024 IBC uses the same logic for building-code roof assemblies, stating that roof coverings are to be designed and installed according to the code and manufacturer-approved instructions [3]-[4]. This means the product-specific instruction manual is not outside the standard. It is part of the standard.

Warranty eligibility

A roof can be physically installed and still lose warranty eligibility if it misses a manufacturer requirement. GAF states that certain limited warranty coverage is conditioned on shingles or ridge cap shingles being fastened and installed strictly according to GAF application instructions [32]. TAMKO's Heritage instructions warn that failure to follow manufacturer instructions will adversely affect limited warranty coverage [38]. Owens Corning warranty resources and system warranties require qualifying components, contractor status, and registration for certain enhanced warranties [27]-[28].

Brand-specific specifications and the city standard

A brand does not change the law of a city by itself. The city code remains the city code. However, once a specific brand and product are selected for a permitted roof in that city, the manufacturer's written instructions become part of the applicable installation standard because the code and warranty both point to those instructions. In practical terms, the selected product changes the job-specific specification that must be followed.

Manufacturer requirements commonly govern

- roof deck suitability and fastening surface
- minimum slope and low-slope underlayment method
- underlayment type and lapping
- ice barrier and leak barrier placement
- fastener type, length, quantity, placement, and nailing zone
- starter strip requirements
- valley method
- flashing details

- ridge and hip cap requirements
- hand sealing and high-wind details
- ventilation requirements
- accessory compatibility
- mixing or substitution limitations

Inspector Roofing doctrine: highest-standard installation through standards alignment

Inspector Roofing's existing Claim Verifiability™ standard states that evidence must allow neutral third parties to verify conclusions without relying on inspector opinion. It requires objectivity, completeness, traceability, and continuity and excludes coverage determinations from its scope [43]. Code-to-Spec Roofing™ applies the same philosophy to installation quality: the authority is not the contractor's confidence. The authority is the documented intersection of code, product specifications, warranty, and field evidence.

Inspector Roofing Protocols™ treat roofing as a system, not a commodity. The framework evaluates whether the scope complies with adopted code, meets manufacturer requirements, and preserves system integrity. It also requires local-adoption verification, manufacturer-document review, and AHJ alignment before code or manufacturer requirements are represented as necessary work.

Operational standard: the Code-to-Spec Roofing™ workflow

Phase 1 - Jurisdiction verification

8. Identify property address and AHJ.
9. Identify whether the project is one-/two-family residential, townhouse, multifamily, commercial, or mixed-use.
10. Confirm adopted code edition, local amendments, enforcement date, and permit transition rules.
11. Identify special overlays: HVHZ, WUI, coastal wind, flood, historic district, energy/cool roof, snow load, ice barrier, and product approval requirements.
12. Save the code source or AHJ confirmation to the project file.

Phase 2 - Product and system verification

13. Select the manufacturer and exact product line.
14. Download current installation instructions and warranty terms.
15. Identify deck, slope, underlayment, flashing, fastener, ridge/hip, starter, ventilation, valley, and accessory requirements.
16. Identify whether enhanced warranty requires a complete system, approved contractor status, registration, or accessory package.
17. Confirm substitutions or deviations in writing before installation.

Phase 3 - Design-to-installation translation

18. Translate code and spec into a scope of work.
19. Map each scope item to a requirement: code section, AHJ rule, manufacturer instruction, warranty term, or safety requirement.
20. Do not include unsupported upgrades or boilerplate items.
21. Do not omit required components merely because they are unseen in a pricing template.
22. Where code and manufacturer instructions conflict, consult the AHJ and manufacturer technical department; do not guess.

Phase 4 - Field execution

23. Stage the job safely and document fall protection/access limits.
24. Photograph existing conditions before tear-off.
25. Photograph decking, underlayment, flashing, valleys, penetrations, vents, edges, starter, ridge/hip, and final system details.
26. Record product names, batch/lot numbers where available, and warranty registration requirements.
27. Document deviations, discovered conditions, and corrections.

Phase 5 - Closeout and proof package

28. Provide a code-to-spec installation checklist.
29. Provide manufacturer instructions used.
30. Provide warranty registration or warranty eligibility documentation.
31. Provide permit inspection documentation where applicable.
32. Provide photo proof organized by assembly sequence.
33. Provide homeowner maintenance/warranty summary.

Warranty analysis: why installation quality is a documentation problem

Roof warranties are often misunderstood as marketing promises. In practice, they are conditional documents. The condition is typically not "the roof looks good." The condition is that a covered product was installed properly, by a qualified party where required, as part of a qualifying system where required, and under the warranty terms in effect at purchase or installation.

Major warranty risk areas

- Improper fastening: wrong fastener type, overdriven nails, underdriven nails, nails outside the nailing zone, inadequate fastener length, or missed high-wind nailing patterns.
- Improper underlayment: missing low-slope two-layer method, incorrect laps, missing ice barrier or leak barrier, or incompatible underlayment.
- Ventilation defects: inadequate intake/exhaust balance or blocked ventilation can create heat/moisture problems and warranty exclusions.

- Accessory mismatch: starter, ridge, hip, leak barrier, roof deck protection, ventilation, and accessory components can affect enhanced warranty eligibility.
- Product substitution: brand substitutions may break a system warranty even if the substitute is otherwise code-compliant.
- Deck defects: weak, deteriorated, gapped, or non-nailable decks can undermine fastening and warranty performance.
- Flashings and penetrations: reused or improperly integrated flashings often create leaks and may not satisfy manufacturer or code requirements.

State-by-state adoption matrix

Source and limitation: This table uses the Code Check state-code compilation last updated February 5, 2026 and is supplemented by official state examples cited in this paper. Code Check itself warns that local adoption nuances and contradictions can exist and that local building departments must be consulted [5]. The matrix is therefore an operational starting point, not a legal determination.

State	Residential code / IRC adoption snapshot	Governance notes	Inspector Roofing Code-to-Spec response
Alabama	2021 IRC	Residential now under Home Builders Licensure Board.	Statewide baseline must be verified with licensing board and local AHJ before reroof scope.
Alaska	No statewide IRC listed; Anchorage shown on 2018 IRC	Applies to Anchorage; rest of state is local.	Treat as local-adoption state; verify municipality before writing code scope.
Arizona	2018 IRC	Entirely up to local jurisdictions; varies widely.	City code controls; product specs and local amendments must be checked before material selection.
Arkansas	2021 IRC for state buildings	Applies to state buildings only, not local.	Local AHJ verification is mandatory for residential reroof projects.
California	2024 IRC basis through California Residential Code / Title 24	Mandatory statewide minimum; Los Angeles and San Francisco may amend.	Apply Title 24, energy/cool-roof rules where triggered, WUI/Hazard rules where applicable, plus local amendments.
Colorado	2021 IRC example for Denver/state buildings	Home-rule state; local jurisdictions vary.	Verify city/county code, especially wind, wildfire/WUI, snow load, and underlayment requirements.
Connecticut	2021 IRC	Statewide.	Use statewide code plus local permit and manufacturer requirements.
Delaware	2018 IRC listed, not statewide	Local jurisdiction determines.	AHJ confirmation is required before assigning code upgrades.
District of Columbia	2015 IRC	Applies to entire district.	Use DC amendments and permit rules; manufacturer specs remain job-specific.
Florida	2021 IRC basis through 2023 Florida Building Code, Residential	Statewide; local amendments and HVHZ requirements where applicable.	Wind zone, product approval, underlayment, deck fastening, HVHZ, and Florida product approval must be addressed.
Georgia	2024 IRC with Georgia Amendments	Statewide minimum; enforcement by local AHJ.	Confirm Georgia amendments and local permit transition dates; align with manufacturer system requirements.
Hawaii	2018 IRC listed	Each county must adopt; some may lag.	County code and coastal/wind exposure rules must be confirmed.
Idaho	2024 IRC	Statewide with amendments.	Use state-adopted code and local amendments, with attention to snow and wind exposure.
Illinois	Local adoption of current editions	No uniform statewide IRC; local jurisdictions vary.	Treat as local-adoption; document municipal code edition and amendments in every file.
Indiana	2018 IRC listed	Statewide, requires local adoption; uses IRC electrical.	Confirm local adoption/enforcement and residential amendments.
Iowa	2024 IRC	Statewide.	Use statewide code plus AHJ details and manufacturer instructions.
Kansas	2018 IRC example	No statewide code; local jurisdictions.	Code-to-spec begins with city/county adoption research.
Kentucky	2015 IRC	Statewide code framework; Kentucky-specific plumbing/electrical distinctions.	Use Kentucky residential code and amendments; verify local inspection practices.
Louisiana	2021 IRC	Statewide.	Hurricane/wind requirements and local amendments are critical in coastal parishes.
Maine	2021 IRC	Enforceable for cities with population over 4,000.	Verify municipality size/enforcement and local amendments.
Maryland	2021 IRC	Statewide with local amendments.	County/local amendments often matter; verify local roof permit rules.

Massachusetts	2021 IRC basis	Statewide with local amendments.	Roof covering application includes manufacturer instructions; use 780 CMR and local building department guidance.
Michigan	2015 IRC for residential	Statewide; residential 2015 IRC while building code may differ.	Use Michigan Residential Code and distinguish residential from commercial/multifamily work.
Minnesota	2018 IRC	Statewide with extensive amendments.	Check state amendments, ice barrier/snow load/ventilation, and local practices.
Mississippi	Local choice among 2012, 2015 or 2018 IRC	Adopted at local level.	Local code edition must be confirmed before code upgrades are asserted.
Missouri	2018 IRC example	Adopted locally; example shown for St. Louis.	Treat each municipality separately; code scope cannot be generalized statewide.
Montana	2021 IRC	Local jurisdictions have option to enforce.	Verify whether local jurisdiction enforces the residential code.
Nebraska	2018 IRC listed	Electrical statewide; other codes local.	Local code and permit verification controls reroof scope.
Nevada	2024 IRC	Statewide with local amendments; uses UMC mechanical.	Confirm city/county amendments and wind exposure rules.
New Hampshire	2021 IRC	Statewide.	State code applies; verify local administrative amendments and permits.
New Jersey	2021 IRC	Statewide; national plumbing code distinctions.	Use Uniform Construction Code and local permit process.
New Mexico	2021 IRC	Statewide; also adopts 2021 UMC mechanical.	Use state code and local AHJ requirements; manufacturer specs remain component-specific.
New York	2024 IRC basis / 2025 Residential Code of NYS	Statewide except New York City.	Differentiate NYS from NYC; local energy and snow/wind amendments can affect roof assemblies.
North Carolina	2015 IRC basis through 2018 NC Residential Code	Updates delayed; current code resources should be checked.	Use NC amendments and high-wind/coastal chapters where applicable.
North Dakota	2021 IRC	Statewide.	Use state code and local inspection practices.
Ohio	2018 IRC listed	Statewide; 2021 IBC for other than one-/two-family.	Separate one-/two-family from commercial/multifamily; verify local enforcement.
Oklahoma	2018 IRC listed; moving toward 2024 I-Codes	Statewide framework with pending updates.	Confirm latest effective edition before applying code upgrades.
Oregon	2021 IRC, 2024 codes effective April 1, 2026	Statewide with transition.	Use project permit date to determine applicable code; transition dates matter.
Pennsylvania	2021 IRC	Most jurisdictions opt in; Philadelphia has custom code.	Verify municipal opt-in and Philadelphia-specific requirements when applicable.
Rhode Island	2021 IRC	Statewide.	Use statewide amendments and local permit requirements.
South Carolina	2021 IRC	Statewide.	Wind-borne debris, coastal exposure, and product installation requirements should be documented.
South Dakota	2021 IRC	Local jurisdictions have option to adopt.	Verify the city/county code and enforcement status.
Tennessee	2021 IRC listed; residential may still be 2018 IRC	State/local nuance.	Confirm local residential edition before asserting code-triggered work.
Texas	2021 IRC in some programs / local adoption generally	Local can be more current than state; local adoption controls.	Contact local jurisdiction; document city code and amendments before scope.
Utah	2024 IRC	State buildings; local adoptions may lag.	Confirm local adoption and amendments, especially snow, wind, and wildfire provisions.
Vermont	No IRC listed; IBC adoption noted	Adopts IBC and not the IRC per Code Check snapshot.	Verify state/local residential enforcement path; do not assume IRC applies.
Virginia	2021 IRC	Statewide.	Use Virginia Uniform Statewide Building Code and local permit process.
Washington	2021 IRC, update scheduled May 2026	Statewide with upcoming update.	Permit date matters; verify current Washington amendments and energy code implications.
West Virginia	2018 IRC	Statewide.	Use state code and local AHJ enforcement details.
Wisconsin	2015 IRC modified as Wisconsin Uniform Dwelling Code	Statewide modified code.	Use Wisconsin UDC rather than assuming unamended IRC language.
Wyoming	2024 IRC listed, local adoption	Entirely up to local jurisdictions.	Treat as local-adoption; verify municipality or county before scope.

State-law patterns and roofing implications

Statewide adoption states

Where a state adopts and enforces a statewide code, the starting point is more predictable. Georgia, Florida, Connecticut, Iowa, Louisiana, New Jersey, New Hampshire, Rhode Island, Virginia, and several others maintain statewide code frameworks. Even in these states, local permits, local administrative amendments, wind exposure, product approvals, flood requirements, and special overlays can change the job-specific requirements.

Local-control states

Arizona, Colorado, Kansas, Missouri, Nebraska, South Dakota, Texas, Wyoming, and others rely heavily on local adoption. In these states, a statewide claim that "the code requires" is particularly risky unless the jurisdiction has been verified. Inspector Roofing treats local-control states as code-research states: the project file must show the municipality/county code edition before code-triggered work is asserted.

Custom-code states

California, Florida, New York, Massachusetts, Wisconsin, and North Carolina illustrate the custom-code problem. These jurisdictions may be based on an ICC model code but are not identical to the unamended national code. A contractor citing "2024 IRC" in California, for example, may miss Title 24, local amendments, energy provisions, WUI/fire exposure, and product limitations.

Transition-date states

States and cities regularly adopt new code editions with future effective dates and transition windows. Georgia's 2024 IBC/IRC with Georgia amendments became effective in 2026 [6]-[7]. Oregon's 2024 code transition was listed for April 1, 2026 [5]. Washington had an update scheduled for May 2026 in the Code Check snapshot [5]. For Code-to-Spec Roofing™, the permit date matters as much as the code edition.

Code-to-Spec examples

Example 1 - Same city, different brand

A city adopts the 2024 IRC. A homeowner chooses a GAF laminated asphalt shingle. The code requires installation under the applicable code and manufacturer instructions. GAF's instructions and warranty conditions define fastener type, placement, starter strip, ridge cap, ventilation, underlayment, and wind warranty details. If the same homeowner chooses Owens Corning Duration, the legal code may be unchanged, but the product-specific spec changes. That is a Code-to-Spec difference.

Example 2 - Florida HVHZ

In South Florida HVHZ jurisdictions, roofing work can involve product approvals, underlayment requirements, and installation details beyond generic shingle instructions. A Code-to-Spec

installation must satisfy Florida Building Code, local HVHZ requirements, product approvals, and manufacturer instructions [8]-[10].

Example 3 - Local-control Texas city

Texas code adoption generally occurs at the local level, although state programs such as Industrialized Housing and Buildings may adopt specific editions [15]-[16]. A Code-to-Spec installation in Texas therefore begins with the city code and local amendments, then proceeds to manufacturer specifications and warranty eligibility.

Example 4 - Georgia statewide minimum with local enforcement

Georgia's DCA lists 2024 IBC and 2024 IRC with Georgia amendments as current mandatory codes for construction effective in 2026 [6]. Atlanta aligned its permitting transition to those newly adopted state codes [7]. Inspector Roofing's Georgia workflow verifies the DCA code, local enforcement/transition date, permit requirements, and product-specific specifications before installation.

Code-to-Spec and insurance claims

This paper is not a coverage paper. However, roofing insurance claims often involve scope disputes where code and manufacturer requirements are discussed. Inspector Roofing's position is that code and manufacturer requirements must be presented as evidence-backed construction requirements, not as pressure tactics. The claim file should show the observed condition, the triggered requirement, the required scope, and the evidence path.

Xactimate or any estimating platform does not decide code, scope, warranty, or manufacturer compliance. It translates a justified scope into priced line items. Code-to-Spec Roofing™ requires the standard first and the estimate second.

Minimum Code-to-Spec installation proof package

34. AHJ code edition and local amendments verified.
35. Permit number or permit determination, where applicable.
36. Manufacturer installation instructions saved in the file.
37. Warranty document and warranty eligibility checklist.
38. Material list with product names and accessory components.
39. Deck condition photos after tear-off.
40. Underlayment and ice/leak barrier photos.
41. Flashing, valley, drip edge, rake, eave, starter, ridge, hip, vent, and penetration photos.
42. Fastener pattern proof where feasible.
43. Ventilation verification.
44. Final exterior photos.
45. Inspection approval or closeout record.
46. Homeowner warranty and maintenance summary.

Inspector Roofing standard statement

Inspector Roofing and Restoration follows Code-to-Spec Roofing™ by treating every roof as an assembly governed by public code, local AHJ enforcement, written manufacturer specifications, safety law, warranty terms, and system performance. The company does not treat code as a generic argument. It identifies the adopted code, verifies local amendments, selects the product standard, documents manufacturer requirements, executes the installation to the governing specification, and preserves the record needed for third-party verification.

This is the installation-side companion to Claim Verifiability™. Claim Verifiability™ governs whether a roof claim can be reviewed objectively. Code-to-Spec Roofing™ governs whether the installed roof can be justified objectively.

Conclusion

The highest roofing standard is not simply "better materials" or "experienced installers." It is a documented compliance system. In the United States, roof installation is governed by a layered authority structure: state and local code adoption, AHJ enforcement, product-specific manufacturer instructions, safety obligations, warranty eligibility, and system performance. Because state and local code adoption varies dramatically, no responsible contractor should rely on generic code statements. Because manufacturer specifications are incorporated into code and warranty eligibility, no responsible contractor should ignore product-specific instructions. Because roof systems fail at transitions, ventilation, fastening, underlayment, and compatibility, no responsible contractor should treat roofing as isolated shingles.

Code-to-Spec Roofing™ is the Inspector Roofing answer to that complexity. It is a formal standard for identifying the governing rules, executing the installation, and documenting the result so the homeowner receives a roof installed to the highest verifiable standard.

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